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Sexual solidarity and the secrets of sight and sound

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sexual solidarity and the secrets of sight and sound

A certain ambivalence does emerge, however, as the situation highlights the contradiction and brings out the tension ordinarily defused by the dispersal of women. It emerges in the encouraging speeches made to girls, in side comments made during initiation ceremonies, and in joking attacks made by men on the women's house of ritual. Women's abilities and strength of will are at once recognized and denied.

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The contradictions of gender relations are also displayed when initiates are asked to confess their social debts (*pesenweek*) during the first ceremony. This ritual event is intended to clear the air of all hidden resentments that adults may hold against the initiates. Otherwise, they might harm the initiates during their operations. The confessions can be actually embarrassing for initiates and uproariously funny for the audience. Girls are asked to describe times when they refused to help with work or to go on errands for adults, and to name those involved. They are also pressed to name young men whose amorous advances they have refused. Accepted norms prescribe respectful obedience by children and reasonable behavior by adults. These expectations are at once countered and supported by accounts of willful independence, petty arguments, insistent coercion, and refusals that are often quite reasonable (Kratz 1989c).

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It is during the *pesenweek* confessions that age differences become especially salient. However, the hierarchy of age is also evident in the authority of elders in matters of ceremonial organization, an authority of age incorporated into ceremonial structure and also created by the elders' role as blessers. Similarly, the two ritual teachers (*matireenik*) who conduct initiates through the secrets of initiation represent and carry the authority of ritual knowledge, experience, and tradition reaffirmed and passed on. *Matireenik* first conduct the girls into the women's house of ritual on the night of the first ceremony. Beginning then, and continuing throughout the ceremonies of seclusion, there is a permutation of the principal tension and contradiction of gender relations evident in initiation. In seclusion, the main dialectic becomes that between intrasexual equality and the hierarchy of authority based on age.

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Sexual solidarity within the ritual communities of initiated women and initiated men is forged and focused in each case through the trial shared and the secrets revealed in seclusion from (or with the exclusion of) the opposite sex. It is consolidated through continued ceremonial participation throughout their lives. Initiation is a formative experience, the grounding of an irrevocable equality among women or among men. As seclusion songs say, "*kitece matireen; matireen ko poko*" ("we respect ritual leaders; ritual leaders are many [hundreds]"); all adult women share equally in the ritual knowledge of the initiated.

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The solidarity created through shared experience and knowledge is fundamental in establishing the ritual community of the initiated, yet that basic equality is not undifferentiated. The ritual community is hierarchical, with distinctions of authority created through differential control and access to the secrets of initiation. A hierarchy of ritual knowledge is defined within each sex by the correlated dimensions of age and experience, which are also relevant generally in Okiek social relations.

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Initiates must honor and obey their ritual leaders and initiated women during initiation on pain of being beaten, just as women are told and expected to heed their husbands (who also beat them, but more seriously); initiates are also enjoined to sustain this respect after initiation, though in less exaggerated form. Seclusion teachings lay the bases for differences of status and authority among women (or men) as well as between men and women, though such distinctions may be foregrounded in some circumstances and backgrounded in others. As initiates are shown the secrets of initiation and

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learn women's secret songs, their equality with other adult women is framed by the hierarchical relation between initiates and ritual teachers. Even as they  459 near the end of their seclusion period, however, and are increasingly familiar with most of the secrets of sight and sound, that tension remains, concentrated and embodied in the final secret to be revealed, *cemaasiit*.

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